

Religion and Science

Religionshistoriske Smaaskrifter I

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In every culture we know, a critical condition arises as soon as the division of labour takes hold. In the material sphere it becomes impossible for the individual worker to produce anything in which he can feel that he has worked with all his powers. As a rule he can now make only a single part of a whole, a part that calls for no more than one of his faculties. His powers and his talent thus develop one-sidedly; and, like his work, his very personality readily shrinks to a fragment. In the spiritual sphere the division of labour means that art, science, religion, and morality, which once formed a single whole, now draw apart, and often confront one another as rival powers. In earlier ages religion was the great central current of life: every spiritual force and impulse fed into it, and it in turn fully satisfied whatever need for art or for knowledge had yet begun to stir. But little by little the spiritual needs seek their satisfaction along separate paths. The desire to inquire is no longer content with the answers that religious ideas can give to the countless questions raised by life and experience. Special methods take shape, special ways of framing the questions and of seeking the answers. The artistic impulse too goes more and more its own way, and men seek an independent foundation for moral judgement. History shows that, against these new developments, religion tends to cling to the ideas and the ways of acting once established. It resists the spiritual division of labour as long as it can, and closes its eyes as long as possible to the changed conditions of spiritual life. Hence a division, a fragmentation, of spiritual life. What is missing is that gathering and harmony, that concentration of all the mind's forces in one common direction, which under the older conditions was comparatively easy to reach. This is why a religious problem exists, and why it will go on existing until the spiritual life of

individuals, and of mankind as a whole, has found new and gathering forms in which to satisfy its innermost need—if indeed such new forms are possible at all.

I shall bring forward here only a few features of the intellectual side of the problem. For me the whole question is by no means exhausted when it is viewed from this side alone. Yet it is of great importance to see clearly what the opposition between religion and science, which asserts itself again and again, really rests upon. Often—and this is true of both the parties that here confront one another—the ground of the opposition is located in the wrong place. On the one side there is much superficial and dogmatic insistence on the real or supposed results of science; on the other, much short-sightedness about the change that the life of thought has in fact undergone, quite apart from those many conspicuous results. In the collisions to which the opposition leads, an onlooker will find no lack of honesty in the professions made on either side. For nowadays there is, after all, comparatively little risk in professing one's convictions, whichever way they run. What he will often find lacking is that intellectual integrity which refuses to let the mind rest until the great questions have been examined from every side and by every means at one's disposal. This, unfortunately, is not a virtue that religious ethics has been at pains to instil; and many of religion's opponents show, by the tone of their polemic, that they too are strangers to its strict demands. What an onlooker misses here is bound up with the fact that in our day religious debate has mostly the character of agitation. On both sides the aim is to win adherents, to spread a view abroad, not to deepen it. New thoughts, accordingly, this modern debate has not brought forth either.

What I wish to offer here is likewise not new thoughts, but old ones that have never been allowed to come fully into their own.

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If we go back to ages in which religion was not merely help and consolation but also answered whatever thought could then ask—ages, that is, in which the whole view of the world bore a religious stamp—two features especially stand out. The whole conception of the world is intuitable in character. Existence presents itself as a whole whose several regions can be seen, or at least pictured, without any need to break with what the senses immediately seemed to teach. Cosmic space, as it offered itself to sense and imagination, left room to assign a place to all the great events with which religious proclamation was concerned. And when changes—above all momentous changes—broke into this intuitable world, *the explanation* was not to be sought along the arduous road of inquiry. Such changes were explained by the intervention of personal beings in the course of events. It is intuitability, together with the principle of personal causes (what in the

widest sense may be called animism), that marks off a specifically religious view of the world.

But under the influence of the independent urge to knowledge, both the concept of space and the concept of cause have undergone changes that are here of decisive importance.

1. We have a natural urge to assign everything that happens to some definite place in space, and religion in its classical periods does not deny this urge. Religious ideas have the character of intuition, not of concept, and much of their great influence—their power to grip and to fill the mind—rests upon this. The content of the higher popular religions is a series of historical events into which the destiny of men and the life of man are woven: a great drama, and one played out upon a stage—sense- intuition—which the imagination can at all events readily take in without being overtaxed. The whole of existence, so far as it is accessible at this stage, is drawn onto this stage, and its various regions supply the settings for the various scenes of the drama. The earth stands at the centre, or at the lowest point; and from the visible heaven, which is the world of the deity, divine beings come down to intervene in the fate of men—perhaps themselves to suffer and die—before they ascend once more into the heavenly regions, to which they then open the way for those who will follow them. “All men,” says Aristotle, “suppose that there are gods, and all, both Hellenes and barbarians, assign to the deity the highest place.” The saying holds of all popular religions, however much they may otherwise differ. Religious ideas wove themselves naturally into the whole picture of the world that men formed without reflection, and as yet there was no science to force any radical change in that picture. The idea of the divine had nothing vague or blurred about it: the divine could be located like everything else; one could point to the place from which the divine forces welled up, and to the place where they did their work. The thoughts of the gods were indeed raised as high above the thoughts of men as heaven above earth; but heaven was precisely not raised so high above earth that intuition had to give up. For all the difference in power and dignity, a vivid and intimate relation to the gods remained possible. No popular religion has given up this picture of the world. Yet even before science had seriously shaken the intuitability of the world, misgivings arose among thoughtful minds, and the assurance with which men had hitherto rested in the intuitable world-picture, as the frame for the whole content of religion, began to waver. This unrest sprang in essential part from a deepening of the religious consciousness itself. Two urges stir in all religion: on the one hand the urge to lift the object of religious ideas as high above human and earthly conditions and forms as possible, and on the other the

urge to feel oneself at one with the deity, or at least to be near it—the urge to stand before an Exalted One, and the urge to an intimate relation with the Highest. Either could bring about a break with the naïve intuitability of popular religion. If the deity is to be exalted above all things, must it not be exalted above all distinctions of place as well, above the very possibility of being located and bounded? And if it is to stand in the closest relation to man, can it be separated in space from the human being with whom it is to be one? A distance in space is always an external relation, however swiftly it may be crossed. Both tendencies can be traced in the original religious documents themselves; a purely religious urge makes itself felt there, one that was bound to lead out beyond intuitability. To this was joined the influence of philosophical reflection—in the case of Christianity, above all the influence of Platonism. It was under the working of these several motives that Augustine could say of his God that he was “everywhere and nowhere,” that he had his place “further within the soul than its own inmost being,” and “higher than the soul could ever climb.” But this was won only after a hard struggle—bodily as well as spiritual—between the religious materialists (anthropomorphists), who clung to absolute intuitability, and the religious spiritualists, who denied it.

In theory it was spiritualism that won. But men could not, and would not, wholly deny intuitability, which after all appears so plainly and unambiguously in the original religious documents, and is besides of such great pedagogical value. A narrative like that of Jesus’ ascension positively requires, if it is to be taken literally, that heaven be conceived as a definite place, up to which the journey went; the ascension is a passage from the earthly part of space to the heavenly. The theologians of the Middle Ages then took to teaching that the ascension meant a passage into another kind of existence, a spiritual mode of being: to ascend to heaven is to lay aside earthly and human limitation. Yet this symbolic reading did not, for them, rule out the literal one. Men held fast to intuitability and to symbolism at once. A passage has really taken place from physical earth to physical heaven, and yet this very passage means at the same time something else. The literal and the figurative sense of “the Higher” as against “the Lower” are both retained—though men plainly incline to lay the greater weight on the figurative. It was supposed that this twofold meaning—realistic and idealistic, literal and edifying—had been laid down in the original accounts themselves. What for the original religious consciousness was a single undivided truth, intuitable and significant at one stroke, became for the medieval consciousness a Both—And, at once separate and inseparable.

In Dante’s great poem this standpoint prevails. Here too the symbolic meaning is the one that lies nearest the poet’s heart; but the ideal truth is given a corresponding

outward garb, whose reality is firmly maintained. Seen from this point of view, the singular achievement of the *Divina Commedia* lies precisely in this: that the outer framework holds firm, with a solidity and an intuitability that the religious poetry of later ages could not attain, and that the inwardness nonetheless comes fully into its own through the symbolic interpretation shining through it. The passage from the material to the ideal is made—at once naïvely and grandly—at the very boundary of space: the outermost heaven, which encloses all things, has its own “Where?” in the deity, whose power and love are the source of the wheeling of the worlds.

But the time came when men demanded a more prosaic answer to the question “Where?” Just as, within our experience, we fix every place by its relation to another, so we must suppose that the same holds everywhere in the world, wherever we may imagine ourselves to be. No absolute places, no absolute boundaries, can then be thought. Every intuitable object has its “Where” in the literal sense, fixed by relation to other places. Hence no centre of the world and no boundary of the world can be pictured, and no place can be pointed out from which the divine forces might stream forth or down. At every place the same law—or rather the same method for determining place—must apply. It was precisely this train of thought that led Giordano Bruno to draw his bold conclusions from the hypothesis of Copernicus. Lucretius had already hinted at it in his famous didactic poem, but only much later did it become possible to grasp it firmly and put it to use. Against the immeasurable world of space now opening up, the ancient contrast between heaven and earth had to dwindle to nothing. That space is in fact infinite cannot, in a certain sense, be proved. What matters is the new method, the new way of thinking, when place and space are in question. It is, in a manner of speaking, a new organ that develops, one that thought carries with it wherever in the world of space it may go. Against this new way of thinking the old world-picture with its absolute places could not stand. The passion with which men held to it so long, and with which they fell upon the champions of the new world-picture, shows that they too had some inkling of what was at stake. For what was at stake was nothing less than the surrender of the literal sense of the religious representations. Every popular religion had built upon the old, absolute, bounded world-picture. It gave the religious imagination its ground and its foothold, and gave the human spirit that sense of being at home in a world where its highest ideals could have their “natural places” no less than the meanest material elements had theirs.

The medieval Both—And would now no longer serve. The events that the biblical writings recount so circumstantially and so vividly must now, at decisive points, be

understood figuratively. One can no longer make shift with assuming both a real and an ideal meaning. The narrative of the ascension is the typical case, for it says plainly that the whole universe is affected by what happened in Palestine: a heavenly power had come down to earth and now left it again to return to its natural place.

Only very rarely does the religious consciousness seem to grapple in earnest with the questions that now arise—questions important both for the historical understanding of the biblical narratives and for the character of the religious world-view. If the narrative of the ascension cannot be literally true, then it stands as a legend that may keep its beauty and its ideal meaning once we put ourselves back into the thought of the age, but that can no longer press its claim with dogmatic weight. On an essential point, then, men have granted the legitimacy of the historical-critical method. For that method rests on the same assumption as Bruno's extension of the way of determining place from earth to heaven: that in investigating what is distant we can do nothing but apply the procedure we have tested on what is near. We must approach the old accounts with the conception of the world we now hold, however far it may differ from the one that underlies them. But the consequences matter not only for the historical method. The whole significance that can attach to religious representations must thereby be altered. No wonder men would rather let the matter lie! And yet even orthodox theologians turn symbolist and rationalist in spite of themselves, once they think their way seriously into the subject. Martensen, for instance, insists that the account of the ascension is to be taken literally. Yet since heaven is no definite place, and since the narrative can only mean that Jesus now left the spatial, sensible world, he holds that Jesus raised himself only a little way into the air, as a sign to the apostles that he was now entering a wholly different kind of existence from the sensible one! Martensen is driven to this tasteless reading of the old account by his own claim that the Bible does not mean, by heaven, a place one reaches by long roads. He begins from the symbolic meaning of the image of heaven—and still insists on taking the old narrative literally. What was a tenable position for a medieval theologian had become an untenable one in the nineteenth century, or should have.

There is nothing for it but to lay the whole weight on the symbolic meaning. That is the only way the old accounts can come fully into their own—religiously, poetically, and historically. In every "edifying" use of them one really takes this path. Only so can we rightly understand what stirred in the human minds to which these accounts are due. The "natural places" of the religious events are to be found within souls, and there alone. All legends and myths are but testimonies to what gripped men's minds in a given age and set the imagination working. And it is the task of historical research to

discover what outward events helped to bring about these inward happenings, and so to make a searching psychological understanding of them possible. Historical research must in turn, as already noted, start from the marks of reality that we everywhere use when we try to find our bearings in the world around us. How far one can go along this path, and what religious significance the results of the historical study of the origin and development of religion may come to have, is a question of its own, which I shall not take up here. For my own part I believe that the so-called liberal theology sets too great hopes on it. — I return to the question of how the thought of the immeasurability of existence bears on the religious consciousness. It is by no means only the popular religions that the problem here arising concerns. Every view of life, religious in the narrower sense or not, must be touched by it. Every human reflection on the worth of life and the conditions of life must reckon with the fact that human life, with its interests and ideals, its victories and its defeats, fills only a vanishing point in the world we know. We can no longer make the whole world the stage for the drama of life. The stage on which that drama is played is small and vanishing—and what meaning and worth, then, belongs to all the rest of the immeasurable universe? It is striking how little weight, as a rule, has been laid on this question, in philosophy as in theology, especially once the first impression of the new conception had worn off.

For Bruno it was a spiritual liberation when the narrow boundaries of the world fell away before his reflection. To his poetic-philosophical vision, existence now stood as one great unity, everywhere ensouled by the same spirit and upheld by the same forces. Jacob Böhme too came to see the matter in much this way, once he had struggled clear of the grievous distress into which he was thrown when the infinity of nature first dawned on him, over against the narrowness of the human world. For Holberg it was still the case that astronomy had now made possible a loftier conception of God than the one held not only by the common man but by many theologians as well. Later, however, the question is seldom discussed, and is by preference set aside. Positivists and Romantics here take, at bottom, much the same course as the theologians. Comte's religion of humanity brought in a symbolism in which the great universe served as a background to the globe on which human life unfolds, and even on purely scientific grounds he refused all closer inquiry into the remoter parts of the universe. Hegel (and, among us, Heiberg) scoffed at the "bad" infinity presented by extension in space. In Hegel's view men have overrated the importance of the Copernican system. Though his speculation was to furnish us the fundamental forms in the development of the *World-spirit*, he still maintained that the earth was the most perfect of the globes, because it was there that

spiritual life was to be found. And Grundtvig held that infinite space and the Copernican system held no interest, unless one began from the assumption that sun, moon, and all the stars exist for the sake of men.

There is here, on every standpoint, a contrast between the view of the world and the view of life that may well give us pause. At its inmost, every serious view of life clings to the narrow circle within which human tasks and ideals hold good; yet the gaze cannot but slip out, again and again, to the infinite background. We may hold firmly that in the vanishing corner of existence we inhabit there have grown up forces and forms of life nobler than any we can trace in the rest of the universe; but we command no forms of thought that would let these forces appear as the ones that govern the whole infinite course of the world. From what has the highest value for us we cannot derive or make sense of the orbits of the globes and the surging of the world-processes. A gulf opens before us between the realm of our ideals and the world of matter, a gulf no bridge can span. One may shut one's eyes to this fact; but it is more manly to look it in the face, and to shape one's faith and hope so that they can stand the test on the battlefield of reality. We must have the courage to hold fast that the stream of force and life which in its course has brought us all we know of the great and the beautiful will be able, henceforth too, to make its way through the hard masses of reality—even though we can attach no meaning to the notion that these masses exist only for its sake. —

The intuitability that is the strength of all popular religions holds not only for space but for time as well, and in a quite parallel way. Yet it is not in every popular religion that the idea of time and the idea of a historical development play an essential part. Where they do come forward, they mark a higher ethical stage of development. The guiding interest in the shaping of religious ideas is now no longer merely the momentary, sensuous welfare of individuals or small groups of men; what is at stake is the salvation of a whole people, and in the end of the whole human race. The religious problems then bear on the meaning of the entire course of human history here on earth. And here the history of religion shows us a curious contrast. For at the very stage of development where the urge arose to find meaning in the course of time and the march of history, there was a powerful intellectual tendency that could satisfy this urge only by killing it: the course of time had no worth whatever, and the one thing needful was to halt it, to save one's soul out of it, to pass over into a timeless being. This was the path that development took in India, above all in Buddhism; and Greek thought, which prized the unchangeable above the changeable, moved in a kindred direction. The other line of thought—the one that came to exert the greatest influence on European humanity and

on the whole Muhammadan world—acknowledged the reality of the course of time, but found the possibility of salvation in a great process of development that leads peoples and generations toward a final decision in the mighty world-struggle between good and evil powers within and beyond the human world. It seems to have been from the Old Persian religion above all that this thought went out into the world, whether it first arose there or reaches back further still. All eschatology—all teaching of a development toward a last judgment and a world of glory or of perdition thereafter—seems in essential part to be of Persian origin. It has influenced later Judaism, and through Judaism Christianity, and it is said (on Goldzieher's authority) to have directly influenced Muhammadanism from the very first.

Just as, in respect of space, the world-drama got its bounded stage in the ancient world-picture, so, in respect of time, it got its clear and definite place between the world's beginning and the world's end; and the stretch of time between these two points—the raising of the curtain on the first act and the fall of it on the last—was as little infinite as the spatial distance between heaven and earth. Here too the strength of popular religion lay in intuitability, and in the limitation that goes with it. Here a man saw himself, with all the spiritual and material weal and woe of himself and his fellows, as a link in a great course of development—shaped by a common past, perhaps sighing under the torment of the present, yet looking with confidence to the redemption the future was to bring. Popular religion has here given life a wide horizon, and made it possible to understand the individual's fate and striving from a higher point of view. A real advance in the historical sense was thereby made—and all this without bursting the frame of intuitability. It became possible to form clear pictures of past and future, images in which all the tension and longing, and all the exultation and sense of victory, that life in time can release could find strong, often exalted, and imperishable expression.

But once reflection awakens and is carried through consistently, this intuitability fares as the one about space had fared. The fixed boundaries, the absolute beginning and the absolute end, give way as soon as reflection applies to the moments of beginning and end the same method it applies to the moments in between. In place of the short span (12,000 years, according to Parsism) that the world-drama was to last, there now enters immeasurable time, past and future alike. The question then becomes how far that span of time which man's historical consciousness can take in can be credited with the absolute significance, the rounded and measured character, that the world-view of popular religion so naturally lent it. Can there now be any talk of a world-drama at all? The limitation in which great art shows its mastery becomes impossible for the course

of the world, and with it the dramatic character of that course falls away.

As with the limitation of space, so with the limitation of time: intuitability here too holds out the possibility of a feeling of being at home. It is with the world as with every single being—it has its birth and it has its death. That the world had grown old was a common belief in the first Christian centuries; it was found among the Jews as well, as the remarkable apocalyptic book “the Fourth Book of Ezra” shows. And then, amid the torments and disappointments of the age, one could look forward with gladness to the approaching end. This near conclusion was no fantasy in which men now and then indulged; it stamped the whole view of life, the whole “Christianity of the New Testament.”

As with space, so with time, a peculiar process of inwardization goes on within the religious consciousness itself. It reaches out beyond the distances of time, as it reaches out beyond the distances of space. It will have its object not in a distant future or past, but in present experience. The ideal is not to have vanished, nor to be merely to come, but to make itself felt in the very life lived now. Eternity is not to lie before time or after it, but to be experienced in the midst of time—as psychological experience bears out, when it shows how time drops away from us in those states that are filled with great interests and ideas. In religious mysticism, whose germs lie in the original religious documents themselves but which was carried further in various periods of the history of religion, the thought recurs again and again that true eternity can be experienced in the midst of time, when the will turns away from all that can scatter it and gathers itself about its highest object. In such forms the religious consciousness draws near to the very conception that alone becomes possible once the concept of time is thought through.

When reflection is carried through, we stand before immeasurable time as before immeasurable space. In both we must find our place—the place for our work and for the experiences we can make about the conditions of life. From that place we then follow the course of time forward and backward, as far as we can. But we must reconcile ourselves to the fact that time and events lie before the point at which we can begin, and after the point at which we must end. If our interest is not to be confined to this span of time—vanishing as it is beside what the strict working-out of the concept of time would demand—then we must hold fast the conviction that what has real worth for a surveyable stretch of time need not lose it as time runs endlessly on, even though that worth, through manifold displacements, undergoes decisive changes. Within the periods we can survey we constantly see the same thing repeat itself: what at first was only a

means later took on worth of its own, and what at first stood as a final end later came to serve as a means or a preparation for more comprehensive values. We must give up plotting the sequence of scenes in the world-drama; we cannot tell in which act and which scene our own life falls; the very idea of a drama can be applied only to a bounded time. And none of the dramas that art has produced tells us, by its ending, how things later went with the survivors. Just so are we placed over against the course of the world, when we let reflection have its way. Science is nothing but steady and patient reflection.

2. With the widening of the world-picture in respect of space and time there came, in that remarkable age when modern science was born, a further demand: that the concept of cause be worked out more strictly, and with it a new ideal of knowledge, quite unlike the one that had prevailed in antiquity and the Middle Ages. The principle laid down was this: that just as the events or changes whose cause one sought lay before one as facts of experience, so the causes offered to explain them must be such as can be pointed out in experience. Kepler, who urged this demand with particular force, had himself in his earlier writings appealed to causes that did not meet it, and which he therefore later refused to count as “*valid causes*” (*veræ causæ*). He had taught, for instance, that the planets were held and carried in their orbits by star-spirits. But he came to see that this explanation was scientifically worthless, since these spirits could not themselves be shown in experience to act in the way he had supposed. Magnetism, on the other hand (which he confused with gravity), he took to be a valid cause of the planets’ being kept in their orbits, since it is in fact a force of attraction. Mistaken as this notion was, it was nonetheless in the spirit of the new inquiry. Newton later showed that the force which holds a planet in its orbit obeys the same law as the force which brings the flung stone down to earth. It was a great and exemplary instance of a “valid cause.” Just as every place in space must be fixed by relation to other places, and every moment in time by relation to other moments, so, under the principle of valid causes, every event must be fixed and explained by its relation to other events no less demonstrable than itself. The world of experience thereby comes to stand as a coherent whole, and nature is interpreted by nature itself—just as, in a book, one passage is interpreted by means of others in the same book. Here again the weight falls on method: on the way one puts the question, and the check one keeps on the answer. It is a new organ that the human spirit has developed here, and, like every organ, it can work only in its own definite way. This is what sets the tasks, and this is what conditions the solutions. And with it a new intellectual need has grown up. Hitherto it was really only the formal sciences, logic and mathematics, that had won their independence; now the science of

experience—in its three chief forms, as natural science, psychology, and history—was in principle set free from theological and speculative points of view. And the prospect of the newly opened road so often kindled enthusiasm that men declared, in dogmatic fashion, that everything could be explained by the principle of valid causes, and that the causal series was absolutely coherent. They took to construction, instead of waiting until observation and experiment could show where, in the particular case, the causes lay. It was a confusion of result with task, of facts with principles, of system with method. Yet even in such overreaching men were not wrong about the main thing—that they were on the right road. It was the spirit of inquiry grown conscious of its means and its powers, and therewith conscious of its ideal. For a great ideal now offered itself to knowledge: to work an ever-growing number of experiences into an ever closer and more intimate unity. It is an ideal that at any given moment can be met only approximately; at every step it sounds an *Excelsior!*—and leads on to greater tasks. Science, therefore, cannot become dogmatic when it understands itself. The immeasurability of space and time alone rules out any close of our inquiry. Something new can always turn up—and not only beyond the bounds of the space and time one has so far been able to survey, but within them as well. New differences can appear where there had seemed to be likeness or unbroken connection; an ever richer wealth of nuances and transitions can be discovered within what had seemed so well known. The world can go on growing greater for us, in the great and in the small alike. The very concept of a world comes to stand as an ideal concept that can never be carried through, but constantly opens new horizons. Nor may we even assert that existence is comprehensible, that it can be measured by our thought. It might be likened to $\sqrt{2}$, the irrational number, which can perhaps be determined step by step, by finding ever more decimals, but can never be determined once and for all. The concept of the world as a finished whole is really no scientific concept at all. It is one the religious consciousness has framed in its impatience, to gain a sharp contrast to its representation of God; but for science it denotes nothing given—only a standing task. For science the concept of the world raises just as great a difficulty as the concept of God.

When religion in its classical periods gave not only help and consolation in the course of life but also satisfied the urge to know, the principle it called upon was not that of the “valid causes.” Its explanation of nature was *animistic*: it made the intervention of personal beings its ground of explanation. Just as the world as a whole was held to have been created by an act of will, so the several events in nature, in the life of the soul, and in history were held to be brought about by the action of personal beings. This was above

all how men explained the natural events that bear heavily on human destinies. Storm and earthquake, no less than rain and fruitful seasons, found their sufficient ground in the will of Providence, which now punished or tried, now rewarded and blessed. Decisive changes in the life of the soul were explained not by psychological causes but by divine intervention—as when the reason for Achilles’ mastering his wrath against Agamemnon is put down to Athena’s being sent from Olympus to talk him into reason. The march of history the prophets read as the carrying-out of a divine plan, which bends the hearts of princes and turns the fortunes of peoples to its own purposes. In a faded form the animistic explanation survives in the so-called teleological mode of explanation, which speaks more vaguely of final causes, without going so far as to treat these ends as the expression of personal wills.

Hardly ever, however, has the animistic explanation of nature been carried through consistently. Everyday experience already led men to assume a fixed connection between events that both lay before them as facts, so that the one came to count as the cause of the other. They let such budding inquiry run its own course for a shorter or longer stretch, but regarded the causes it turned up as derived and subordinate; the real causes, the “first causes,” were personal wills. And they supposed, moreover, that even in domains where the derived causes ordinarily held sway, a higher cause could break through and—in the service of the divine purposes—bring about a change that the “natural” laws could not explain.

Here, then, two systems stand opposed, two explanations of the world: the animistic and the naturalistic. Between them there can be no real parley, for neither grants the other’s first principles. They ask in different ways, and so they get different answers. Faced with the miracle (which arises both where a “first” cause closes off the series of “derived” causes and where it intervenes directly in the course of events), science must admit that it cannot disprove it; but it adds that, by its own principle and method, it cannot so much as catch sight of it. It can never come face to face with a miracle; for wherever it cannot bind one event to another by a definite law, it stands at a boundary—a provisional boundary, at least. It then does not understand the event before it; it ends in a problem. The two systems collide more and more sharply in human consciousness, and the victory will fall to whichever can develop itself the more consistently and can serve to bind together the greatest number of exactly determined experiences. Could existence, as it actually lies before us, be better explained in an animistic than in a naturalistic way, the victory would go to the religious world-view. But whatever real and lasting understanding has been won has not been won along that road.

It might seem as though an explanation of nature that finds the true causes in personal forces must already have its full justification and necessity in this: that man, the knowing being, is himself a person. Since all explanation consists in tracing the hitherto unknown back to the known, one might suppose that it is the personal forces—which we feel and know at first hand—that must furnish the ground for all understanding of the rest of existence. And this is, in a certain sense, correct. We cannot leap over our own shadow; the whole of our knowledge of the world is conditioned by the human standpoint and human nature. It is from our own position that we find our bearings in existence as best we can. But the decisive question here must be which sides and properties of our nature we can turn to account when a valid and lasting understanding is to be won. Experience teaches us, often through disappointment and pain, that not all our purposes and expectations can be met. It is originally a practical interest that leads us to put definite questions to existence and to demand definite answers of it. We seek means to our ends; and as soon as we have found that we can reach our ends (those we can reach at all) only along definite paths, by the use of quite definite means, we already stand at the causal relation that all science pursues—the law that binds one event to another. Before such a law our wishes and hopes must bow; if they do not fall away, they must often seek other outlets or more distant prospects. But through the discovery of such a law a little insight has been won into the make-up of existence; and the more such laws we can find, the better our understanding will be. In time a motive other than the original practical need may come to prompt the search for such laws. There can be an immediate satisfaction in finding connection in what had lain scattered, whether or not that connection points the way to our ends. Or rather, to win understanding in the only way it can actually be won may itself become one of our essential ends. It is precisely here that the momentous division of labour comes in, which I mentioned at the outset. It is, to be sure, but a single side of the human personality that finds expression in the intellectual need and capacity, as these appear in their specially developed form. But what must not be overlooked is that in this need and capacity the very nature of personality comes to light. A personality always presupposes an inner unity and connection among all the elements of the soul, all its forces and drives. And this holds not only of the personal life taken as a whole, but of every single endeavour to which it gives itself with full energy. In no single domain can personality deny its own peculiar essence. Within its knowledge, accordingly, it will strive after as wide and unbroken a connection as it can. It will not cease laying stone upon stone to raise a building of knowledge that may stand as a counterpart of the inner connection which makes itself known—as an urge, at the least—in its own essence. On

this rests the deep personal satisfaction that scientific work can yield, the passion it can arouse, and the power it can have to fill a human life. Personality and science are thus not strangers to each other, even though not all the elements of the soul can share equally in scientific work. Personality always reaches further than its own intellectual work can compass and penetrate. Besides the task that honesty and intellectual integrity alike impose—of gaining the most thorough orientation in the world that is possible from the position on which the individual personality stands—it has the further task of working its various interests and endeavours together, and above all of bringing the results of its intellectual work into the closest possible connection with the whole life of feeling and will, with all that is the object of hope and faith. That this great task is harder to solve than it was for other ages of culture gives no one the right to pare something off it from one side or the other. We must let the intellectual line run out according to its own laws before it can be woven, in harmonious fashion, into the whole life of personality. This is the great task ever more definitely laid upon the men of our time—upon those of them, that is, who do not dream with open eyes. The path on which the science of experience has thus set out is therefore no accident. The empirical-scientific method has been wrung from human thought by existence itself, which will let itself be questioned, and will answer questions, only in this way. It is becoming more and more the custom, to be sure, to speak of working methods and working hypotheses; and, as we shall see later, it is of great importance not to confuse the paths we must tread in order to catch sight of the truth with the inmost essence of existence itself. Yet a wholly external and indifferent relation between the path and the goal is, all the same, unthinkable. It tells us something of existence that its laws can be found only along these definite paths. Indirectly, through the working hypotheses themselves, we come to know the nature of existence.

Seen from another side as well, the procedure of science has good ground—provided it is true, as I tried above to show, that there is a deep analogy between this procedure and the very essence of personality. This is naturally not the only thing that has given rise to the method of more recent science; but it may help to explain the deep conviction with which, again and again, in spite of many disappointments and mistakes, men return to this method and seek to carry it further and to apply it in new domains.

In the last generation various things have happened in science that, to an outward view, might seem to shake the trustworthiness of the positions on which the foregoing age had leaned so securely. Men have accordingly been busy proclaiming a bankruptcy. They overlooked what the whole history of science shows—that in a certain sense the

problems grow more numerous the further our knowledge advances. Sharp problems exist at all only for those who think and inquire. And the more varied the experiences we gather, the more tasks are set us; for it is then a matter of bringing the new experiences into connection with one another and with the old, which cannot always be done without altering our earlier assumptions.

With the discovery of radium the principle of the conservation of energy seemed to be shaken. Here was a constant radiation of energy, with no way of pointing out how that energy had been stored up in the substance. This raised new questions and gave occasion for new reflection. But in point of principle it changes nothing in the old method. — At about the same time biology showed that organisms can undergo sudden changes, by which new types are formed. It thereby became necessary to give up the assumption Darwin had put forward, that new types arise as small variations are favoured and developed under the pressure of the struggle for existence. For the mutations, the sudden changes of type, occur independently of the struggle for existence; only once the mutation has taken place does the question arise whether the new type can survive. But here too the assumption is not surrendered that every event must hang together with some other event. The task simply becomes to find the inner and outer conditions under which the mutation takes place. — A third example we may take from psychology, where in recent decades attention has been drawn from several sides to sudden changes of character and personality, to new formations in the psychic domain, especially within the life of feeling and will. Here too the conditions prove more complicated than had perhaps for a time been believed. But the guiding points of view remain in principle the same; it is only harder to carry them through.

The circumstances noted here are a wholesome warning against dogmatism in science. We have been reminded once more that there are more things in heaven and earth than were dreamt of in our philosophy. But truly scientific thinking has no need of such a warning; it follows Hamlet's own counsel, and bids the new and the wondrous welcome, even where our philosophy had not thought of it before¹. — It is thought and science themselves that have opened the great horizons which at the same time set us the great problems. It is not for those whose faith rests essentially on old traditions—traditions they do not always confirm by their own experience of life—to come forward with exhortations to keep the eyes open. —

¹*Hamlet* I, 5. (Horatio.) O day and night, but this is wondrous strange!
(Hamlet.) *And therefore as a stranger give it welcome.*
There are more things in heaven and earth, Horatio,
than are dreamt of in your philosophy.

A special reason for holding fast to the principle of the “valid causes” is that only then does it become possible to put to the test, and to get confirmation of, the cause one believes one has found. When the cause of an event or change we have experienced is sought in a preceding event that has itself appeared in experience, there is the possibility of calling that preceding event forth again and seeing whether the presumed effect then follows anew. If, on the other hand, one appeals to causes that cannot themselves be experienced, whether directly or indirectly, no such confirmation is to be had. A miracle does not let itself be repeated at will. There is no showing whether the personal forces or powers supposed to be its cause are present again, and present in just the same way as the first time. Here lies the real ground of animism’s intellectual barrenness. It can voice the wonder we feel at the striking and the unexpected, but it cannot rightly bid “the stranger” welcome. For that requires precisely this: that the new, through repetition, grow familiar to us and be taken up into the circle of our thoughts—even if this can be done only after a change in our earlier way of thinking. Wonder is but the beginning of wisdom.

In testing a causal explanation by calling the presumed cause forth anew, we assume that the event to be explained has really taken place, that it is no mere illusion. Wonder can often lead to a hasty assumption of reality. But here too the value of the principle of the “valid causes” shows itself. For when we ask what mark we have of an event’s reality, it turns out that we are always thrown back on testing whether it agrees with the experiences we have made before, whether it fits into the whole circle of events and relations that already stand fast for us. It is the mark we use quite involuntarily whenever we are in doubt whether something is real or not. We examine it with our several senses, and we compare the present testimony of the senses with their earlier report. We draw on the experiences of others, so far as we think we can rely on them. And our doubt gives way only when this whole circle of experiences and recollections forms a coherent whole, free of self-contradiction and free of leaps. We apply, then, one and the same method when we test the reality of a single event and when we seek the cause of the event so tested. Historical criticism, accordingly, must apply this method too, whatever accounts it may face. It asks how far the several testimonies agree—whether the one is anything more than a mere echo of the other—whether what is reported squares with what experience teaches us of the course of events in the material and in the spiritual domain—whether the content of the account may not be explained from the narrator’s own personality and state of mind, or from the traditions in which he grew up, and so on. The mark of reality is never any single thing. Reality we discover by a comprehending

activity of thought. A single sight, a momentary vision, however powerfully it may grip us, carries no certainty of truth. What thus suddenly grips us may become a spur to inquiry, to all-round testing, and it may then turn out that a genuine discovery was made. But in itself it has no probative force, either as to the several objects each for itself or as to the explanation of them. When a critic now faces an account that contains a miracle, his question will be whether it is more probable that such an event took place, or that the narrator was mistaken for one reason or another. Here the question will be, among other things, whether the account and its content may not be explained from the spiritual conditions of the age. An account is itself an event, a fact that lies before us; it is not only what is reported, but the very fact that it is reported, that can set inquiry going. Historical criticism therefore applies, in its own way, quite the same method that science applies in every field.

There is, to be sure, an important difference between establishing the validity of general laws and furnishing proof of the reality of a single definite historical event: a law must be able to prove itself ever anew, whereas a historical event occurs but once. Bound up with this is the fact that, on the whole, the more special and concrete the object, the harder it is to show the validity of the causal principle. As regards the possibility of repetition—and with it the possibility of scientific confirmation—there is a whole scale of degrees, from the simplest objects to the most complex. In mechanics, physics, and chemistry it is comparatively easy to bring about repetition, to place oneself before just the same conditions as on earlier occasions and then test whether what follows proves to be the same as before. In the organic domain it is far harder; the state of an organism or an organ varies far more, and depends on far more various conditions, than a mechanical motion or a chemical state. States of the soul waver and shift more still; and historical events, in which forces of nature and manifold organic and psychic conditions work together, admit of a minimum of repetition. Yet it is only differences of degree that make themselves felt in this respect between historical and natural events. Not even in physical nature is there absolute repetition. Where we assume it, the assumption rests on inexact apprehension: we do not carry all the nuances and conditions along with us. Hence the method of investigating what really lies before us is in principle everywhere the same. Historical criticism has only to deal with a larger and more complicated web of relations and circumstances. The same holds of historical characterization—the final determination of the distinctive quality and significance of a historical event or a historical personality. But this side of the matter I shall come to touch on later. —

We return to the miracle, and to animism as a whole, in order to note that within the

religious consciousness itself a criticism can arise against the externality and doubleness that animistic explanation—and especially the assumption of miracles—presupposes or leads to. The personal forces here appealed to are of a wholly different kind from what they are to explain. They come from without and set the thing going. There is then no inner kinship between cause and effect. The divine beings come to figure as agents working in a world foreign to them. Here we meet the urge, mentioned earlier, of the religious consciousness to raise its object as high as it can above all that is finite and earthly. But when this tendency has brought about an external and distant relation between the deity and the world in which man himself has his place, a reaction sets in the opposite direction. Inwardness demands its due. The deity is to be near us, to work in us “from within,” not “from without”—and then it cannot stand in a wholly external relation to “the world” and its forces either. From the religious side, too, men quote the poet’s words: “What kind of God were it, that could only strike upon the world from without?” Were the world something with an independence of its own over against the deity, it would itself be a god; God would have to spend some of his power in working upon it. The miracle, in particular, would really testify to a struggle between two gods, and could in any case be conceived only within a polytheistic religion. For the most inward religiosity the external distinctions fall away, and all the outwardness reported of the deity’s intervention takes on, in the end, only figurative meaning. This movement is carried furthest in mysticism; but there is a mystical element in every inward religious consciousness. And this tendency seems, so far as one can judge, to grow gradually so preponderant that the miracles—once the chief means of proof for religious faith—now stand rather as hindrances, hindrances one quietly wishes away, if not on scientific, then precisely on religious grounds. In every edifying use of the miracle-narratives, accordingly, the symbolism is plainly to the fore. As with space and with time, so here too, with causal explanation, a tendency to symbolize runs through the later stages of the religious consciousness. Often the one thing wanting is just this—that one become clearly conscious of the symbolic character.

Descartes declared in his day that in explaining nature he would make no use of the so-called final causes—that is, would not explain the coming-to-be and constitution of things from the ends they are supposed to serve. This seemed to him presumptuous, since we should thereby be claiming an acquaintance with the intention God had had in bringing things forth. And it is indeed clear that such a knowledge of the ends of things is presupposed in teleological explanation—and presupposed still more plainly in the assumption of a miracle. For to assume a miracle is to assume that there has been

sufficient occasion for the higher powers to intervene in the ordinary course of things. And how is that to be known? Pascal held that such an occasion was at hand when a young girl was healed in the church of Port-Royal; the opponents of Port-Royal denied it. Only a revelation could settle the matter, and it is therefore consistent that the medieval Church already reserved to itself the right to decide, in the particular case, whether a miracle was present or not. In quite recent times the Catholic Church has pressed this anew, on the occasion of the many apparitions of the Madonna in the last half-century.

But it is not only the divine ends that must be known if one is to assume a miracle. One must also be able to decide with certainty that a departure from the law-governed order of nature has really taken place; and this too really presupposes omniscience, for it presupposes insight into the limits of nature's conformity to law—limits that science has not been able to find, and never will. —

The animistic explanation of nature, and above all the belief in miracles, springs partly from a natural urge to understand and explain, an urge that at earlier stages of development could be satisfied by no other means of thought. But the main thing was, and has come more and more to be, that such an explanation of nature made it easier to conceive existence, and the course of things within it, as governed by what stood for the human spirit as the highest good. Personal beings act for ends, and strive after goods for themselves and others. When it is such beings whose intervention accounts for the great changes in nature, in the minds of men, and in history, then in the end a thought of purpose becomes the decisive thing; and when a man can believe his own highest welfare bound up in that purpose, he can feel secure amid the turns of fate. What stands for him as the highest value is then also the ultimate cause of all that goes on in the world of reality.

But at bottom the religious view has here, with the help of animism, reinterpreted reality. The strict mark of reality—which, as shown above, lies always in the possibility of linking event to event according to the principles of the “valid causes”—is set aside, and the great problem of the relation between the ideal realm of values and actual reality is therefore never seriously posed. One does not look the matter squarely in the face; one is in too great a hurry to find consolation, and lets one's wishes decide what shall count as truth and reality. Whatever the religion of the future may become—and whether or not the word “religion” will still fit the faith or the view of life that develops—it will at all events be its distinctive mark that it poses the great questions of life as sharply and definitely as first becomes possible when the great spiritual work of science comes to have a serious share in shaping both the questions and the control over the answers.

In the God-concept of the higher popular religions two thoughts are fused into one: the idea of the highest value and the idea of the absolute cause. Such a unity scientific thinking cannot reach. In experience it finds a shifting relation between the valuable and the real. The Good, the True, and the Beautiful (to use the old trinity) must forever struggle to survive, and must often wrest from reality their right to be. From these ideas we cannot understand the whole of existence. We can perhaps find a stream of light and harmony, and follow it in the hope that it will always be able to keep its course; but that continued course itself we cannot construct. What at one time stands as the highest value—the true Good, True, and Beautiful—is for a later time often only of passing significance, a means, or at least a transitional form, to other values. Constantly, in great things and small, there are displacements and transitions that make it impossible to say which values will go on asserting themselves. A highest value is therefore a concept we cannot fix once and for all. The series of values we cannot think of as closed. And as with this series, so with the series of causes. It keeps lengthening for us; and the new, future links in it we can no more derive in advance from those that precede than we can trace the whole series back to an absolute first link. As far as we can see, forward or backward, in either series, new tasks and problems keep presenting themselves. To think both series brought each to a close, and the one moreover led back to the other, is to want to find the philosophers' stone. And if one begins by believing it has been found, then of course all riddles become easy—all too easy—to read. One might ask whether scientific thinking does not, after all, need a conclusion—whether it cannot frame an idea to mark the last, all-embracing point of view. The answer must be that no such conclusion can in any case be reached by following the series of causes forward or backward; that leads only to ever new tasks, ever new work. Not as a link in the series—whether first or last, beginning or end—can thought find a concluding idea. But the very fact that there is a causal series at all, a world-order that reveals itself in conformity to law, is for thought a characteristic mark of existence as we know it. Therein a great unity makes itself known, a connection in great things and small, not only in the outer world of matter but in our own inner being—surely further within than we can ourselves penetrate. This idea is the scientific limit-concept, which can take on positive form only with the help of more or less poetic analogies. Here we are debarred from the only procedure we have for finding positive determinations of concepts, namely comparison with other objects. That which is to be the bond among all our experiences cannot itself be bound to anything else. “What holds the world together in its inmost core”—to borrow Faust's phrase—can find expression in none of our concepts, since all our concepts are drawn from more special

and limited domains. And to this is added—as will be developed more fully later—that the significance of this limit-concept lies in the understanding it makes possible, by its help, of the several individual existences that experience presents. The “concluding” idea carries a direction to constant work. It is set up not as an object of contemplation, but as the guiding thought whose leadership we have come to recognize. The “concluding” idea therefore really brings no conclusion, but leads us back once more to our workplace in the world of experience.

Every personal view of life will now be conditioned not only by the purely intellectual motives that lead to the idea of a whole system of causes, a great world-order, but above all by the place that whatever stands for the personality as its highest value occupies within that world-order. It will depend, then, on what experiences the individual has had of the struggle of values to survive. The individually distinct character that faith, or the view of life, takes on in different personalities will depend partly on the values whose fate is the object of hope and fear, partly on the experiences one has had—or believes one has had—of that fate. — Into this whole question I shall not here go further. It belongs to comparative religious psychology. A personal view of life must, in the nature of the case, have a far more special and concrete character than a scientific theory has. It arises from the union of the scientific knowledge the individual has gained with his practical experiences of life. — Some remarks on how the relation between faith and scientific thinking shapes itself, or must shape itself, in our own time may nevertheless be set down here.

3. Just as in nature various forces are at work, among which the natural scientist seeks a connection in order, if possible, to demonstrate their unity, so in the human soul too various and often contending forces make themselves felt; and it is a task, not for the man of science alone but for everyone, to find a connection among them, and if possible a harmony.

Thinking and faith are two such forces, or tendencies—often acting on each other, often in sharp conflict, not only because some men will hold to thinking alone and others to faith alone, but also because the two can appear as opposites within a single person and open a rift there. And yet both spring, at their inmost root, from one and the same source: the human personality.

Thought seeks order and law-governed connection among our observations, and where it can find no order and law, it seeks to widen experience and make new observations, led by the hope that what, while it stood alone, had seemed accidental and arbitrary may show itself to be a link in a whole connection once it is set beside a larger

body of experience. Often, however, it must halt, because no solution can be found: the observations are either too few, or so inexhaustible in their manifoldness and variety that no common point of view can be established. Yet thought does not on that account give up its demands and its ideals. No absolute conclusion can be reached; but then we end in a question, in a problem—and to that extent wonder can be not only the beginning of wisdom but also the mood answering to wisdom's last word. Besides, there is, as we have seen, an idea that accompanies thought all the way from first to last, since it marks at once the standing task thought sets itself and what the work of thought arrives at when it succeeds: the idea of a great world-order that makes itself known in the laws of events and in the connection among our experiences. Thought works under a high horizon—though this horizon is always, at the same time, the boundary of what it can reach.

While thought thus strives outward, moving from problem to problem, forever seeking new material and a wider horizon, faith means a gathering, a concentration of mind and will upon a single image, a single object, which for the individual sheds light over life, because he finds expressed in it both what gives life value and what secures the survival of that value through the surging of fate.

The relation between thought and faith is like that between a centrifugal and a centripetal force. The highest thing would be to unite the mobility of thought and its wide horizon with the inwardness and concentration of faith. That, too, is the task set for every serious striving. But in the history of the race and in the life of the individual alike it turns out that this harmony is not so easily won. Again and again a strife breaks out between the opposed forces. Perhaps it is an eternal strife. As long as life lasts, new observations come for thought to order and comprehend, and fate brings new experiences of life for faith to take a stand on. The task of reaching a harmony between thought and faith is therefore set anew again and again, under new conditions; and the strife is thus carried on forever in new forms.

In the nineteenth century this strife ran through various stages. At the century's opening Romanticism proclaimed that the spiritual division of labour was to be at an end. Spiritual life was to form a unity, appearing under various forms in art, in science, and in religion. The unhappy strife was to be over: what thought grasped was to be only another expression of what art beheld and what faith divined. In Denmark it was Henrik Steffens who proclaimed a return to a spiritual state such as was supposed to have existed in a former age that knew nothing of our modern oppositions and distinctions—an age he pictures thus: "In living deed was stamped all that we now seek through words: all

the revolutions and developments of nature, all the mysteries of religion. Life itself, fresh as it sprang from the deity, had at once the meaning we now only divine. Therefore all representations were alive. No trace of the sundering death which in more recent times has made the sciences and poetry, and through them religion, so monstrous.” One sees that Steffens traces the difficulties in the religious domain to the emancipation and specialization of science and art. The line of thought he urged played a great part in Danish intellectual life, from Steffens’ *Lectures* (1802) to Martensen’s *Dogmatics* (1849). But our two greatest religious personalities, Grundtvig and Kierkegaard, protested against it with energy, and their coming led to a sharpening of the opposition between the two spiritual forces. To this were added, in the latter part of the century, the mighty rise of natural science, the advance of the historical method into every spiritual domain, and the reawakened critical philosophy’s testing of the validity of our representations—including the validity of those in which faith gives itself expression. Faced with this state of things, one might well be tempted to take refuge in an absolute cleavage between thought and faith, so that the task became to keep them apart, since only so could both be held fast. Under the influence of Kierkegaard’s writings and Rasmus Nielsen’s lectures I tried this path in my youth; but both experience of life and reflection taught me that it could not lead to the goal. The two spiritual powers cannot remain wholly indifferent to each other. Thought can make faith itself—its motives, its ideals, the representations in which it finds expression—the object of its inquiry; and, on the other side, the work of thought itself springs from an urge akin to the one that leads to faith. There is reason, then, to look more closely into their mutual relation, and so to see under what conditions the collision between them—a collision that cannot be avoided—is likely to take place in the future. We view the whole question somewhat differently now than Romanticism and Positivism, the two chief tendencies of nineteenth-century thought, did.

On two points, both briefly touched upon already, an inner kinship shows itself between scientific thinking and personal life.

a. All science is an effort to find connection among scattered and heterogeneous observations. Men have felt the urge to this at all times. Of itself, in the human spirit, the many observations are worked up into coherent images and thoughts, as involuntarily as the nourishment taken in is turned into flesh and blood in the organism. What separates the various stages in the development of thinking is how many and how exact the observations one has to hand, and how carefully one compares and connects them. That there must be a connection is an assumption that makes itself felt of its own accord—in what strikes us as childish superstition no less than in what we call science, and may

perhaps a thousand years hence no longer be called so. In Egyptian mythology the sun that rose in the morning was not the same as the one that had set in the evening; yet the two were brought into connection all the same, the morning sun being taken for the son of the evening sun. The fall of the stone to earth and the moon's motion about the earth Newton found to be instances of one and the same law; and Ørsted found an inner connection between electricity and magnetism, which had hitherto stood as distinct forces. The passage-graves of the North and the domed tombs of Greek antiquity the archaeologists have set in their historical connection. Psychology shows that the coming and going of our representations obey definite conditions, which can be formulated in broad outline.

The urge to find connection, and the joy in finding it, is rooted, as we have already seen, deep in the very nature of personality. We call a man a personality because a connection makes itself known among his endeavours, his moods, and his representations; and the more vigorous, distinctive, and self-won that connection, the fuller the measure of personality we ascribe to him. A personality is never exhausted in a single state or a single utterance, however characteristic. The personal life has at once a fullness and a unity that reach out beyond each single state, and the measure of a personality lies partly in the compass it spans and partly in the inwardness with which that compass is held together. Science is now nothing but one of the forms in which the urge to fullness and unity expresses itself—a form that appears in marked degree in intellectual natures and scientific geniuses. It is always itself a form of personal life, and no accident in the life of the spirit; it can therefore never come to stand in a purely external relation to that life. For some natures a great spiritual pain may attach to having to stop short at incoherent, or even contradictory, observations and representations—just as for every developed personality there is pain in experiences, promptings, or representations that will not fall into harmony with the character and with the view of life as a whole. Intellectual integrity—which with all its skill and power gathers the observations to be had and binds them into as clear a connection of thought as possible—is then a virtue that gains in significance and necessity the more the kinship between science and personality comes to light. Not everyone can be a man of science; but by ever more paths it becomes possible to come into contact with the treasure of knowledge the race has won along its way, and the individual is answerable for the use he makes of that possibility. It is a form of the love of truth on which, in earlier times, for good reasons, so much weight could not be laid. The love of truth could then show itself only as honesty—care for agreement between confession and belief—or as personal truth—care for agreement

between a man's faith and the real inner life and striving of his personality. The mere fact that room comes to be made for a new kind of love of truth is itself a testimony that the opposition between thinking and faith cannot stand as absolute.

b. It may be objected that science nonetheless leads away from personal life, in that it seeks general laws beside which the several cases, events, and individuals have only a vanishing significance. Far out beyond the individual destinies and the narrow circles in which they unfold, out into the immeasurable worlds of space and time in which a single human life can no longer be descried, thought presses on in its zeal to trace the order and conformity to law of existence. Every personality is precisely single and individual, bound to a definite time and place, whereas science seeks the universal, the general. It is perhaps here that the sharpest opposition between science and personality is to be found.

It is true that science has won its highest triumphs by establishing general laws, and for the present this will remain its most important task. But it would not be right to regard this as science's highest task and final ideal. There will always remain the further task of showing how the several existences find their place within the great world-order—a world-order that at once bears them up and is itself sustained by them. Insight into general laws is, in the end, a means to understanding the several, individual existences. To find the general laws, thought must resolve these existences into their elements, for the most comprehensive laws hold of the elements of things in their mutual relations. Things must be made simpler than they are in reality, so that the most general points of view may be brought to bear. But once this work is done, it is again a matter of joining together what one has taken apart, and of making the general laws and points of view work together toward an understanding of the several, definite wholes that experience presents. The part that developmental hypotheses have played in the last hundred and fifty years points this way. The general laws that have been found are used to form a conception of the solar system, of the development of the globes and of living beings; and thereby natural science itself takes on a historical character. In psychology, likewise, it is not merely a matter of finding general laws for the interplay of representations and drives, but of using them toward an understanding of definite individual personalities. And social statistics is to help us toward an understanding of the development of society. It is the interplay of laws in the real existences that matters in the end. Every individual is, as H. C. Ørsted said, a compound unity; its subsistence is due to a co-operation of laws. And as Leibniz had put it still earlier, we come to know an individuality through the law of development that governs its various states.

Science's task is, in the end, biographical. The complete understanding of the wholes that experience shows us in their constant collision and struggle to subsist—star-systems, globes, organisms, personalities, societies— would be science's real conclusion, but it will forever remain an ideal. Here—and notably in all developmental doctrine—the circumstance already mentioned presents itself: that it is difficult, if not impossible, to test the correctness of the hypotheses, since we stand at last before *unica*, before existences that appear only once in our experience. Here, then, there can only ever be talk of approximation. There will always be an irrational relation between the general and the individual.

Bound up with this is the fact that scientific principles and laws are more and more regarded as working hypotheses, as assumptions whose whole significance lies in their setting thought to work. When it is taught, for instance, that in nature no matter and no force arises or perishes, the significance of the proposition lies in its bidding us, whenever matter or force seems to arise or perish, to look for the other matter or forces out of which it arises or into which it is converted. Should other hypotheses set inquiry going more fruitfully, they would be preferable. The so-called pragmatic tendency in the theory of knowledge has in our day sharpened this view to a point, so that it can often look as though the thoughts we form about existence had really nothing to do with existence itself—and at bottom nothing to do with our own nature either—but were merely chance means of orientation, to be exchanged, whenever need be, for others more serviceable. But, as already remarked, it tells us something of existence that it can be understood only along certain definite paths, even though those paths are not the same in all ages. And we must add that it tells us something of the human spirit too, that it can reach knowledge only by shaping its thoughts in a certain definite way. Long before Pragmatism, the critical philosophy had taught that we must not confuse the forms in which our thoughts move with the properties of existence itself. Both tendencies, Criticism and Pragmatism alike, are symptoms that science is growing less and less dogmatic. Each, from its own point of view, warns against treating the views by which we find our bearings in existence as “eternal truths.” The truth of scientific propositions lies not in their picturing existence for us straight off, but in their containing directions for fruitful spiritual work. Perhaps at some time principles and laws quite other than the present ones will be needed to attain the fullness of observations, and the connection among them, that science is forever seeking. We have not exhausted the possibilities of existence, and we do not know all its demands; and we have surely not exhausted the possibilities of thought-forms that lie in the human spirit either.

This last consideration matters not only for the relation between thinking and faith; it is of special moment in an age that does so much for the popularization of science. The art of popularizing is so hard just because it is not merely a matter of imparting finished results, dogmatically shaped propositions, but of conveying a sense of how the work is done, of its foundation and its limits. The aim must be to lead the reader into the researcher's own workshop, and that can be done only indirectly—by hints, and by awakening him to think for himself. It is the old Socratic method that must be brought to bear, if popularization is to mean anything more than a filling of minds with finished representations whose origin and range go understood. — What holds for science—that a sharp distinction must be drawn between the objects that lie before us and the interpretation we put upon them by means of our forms of thought, our principles and hypotheses—holds also for all faith, all personal view of life. If science has been too dogmatic, prone to treat its thoughts and hypotheses as eternal truths, dogmatism has been able to spread even further in the world of faith. This is because tradition and habit count for more in the domain of faith than in that of science. In science, too, familiar views and traditional conceptions can long hold sway over thought; consciously or unconsciously, the established exerts its influence—as the long dominion of schools, tendencies, and methods shows. But tradition has a still greater power in the domain of religion, where it is perhaps even regarded as a necessity. It is not enough that some solution of life's riddles be offered, or some support for hope and courage: it must also stand fixed where they are to be found, and the religious consciousness feels truly secure only when they are vouched for by venerable tradition. Authority has played, and constantly plays, a decisive part in the religious domain; and the very concept of faith is as a rule understood not as an expression of what a man's own experience of life and reflection have settled in his conviction, but as trust in, and adherence to, a handed-down interpretation of life and its destinies. That gathering and concentration which, psychologically seen, is the distinctive thing about faith, over against the often errant wandering of thought, appears most often as adherence to a proclamation, a historical model—an adherence that bears now the character of childlike trust, now of obedience, now of passionate clinging. And even where the religious consciousness gives itself up to its visions or promptings, and immerses itself in its experiences of the worth and destiny of life, even then the handed-down forms and images will thrust themselves forward, involuntarily and unconsciously, and stand as the only natural expression of what has been seen and lived through. In a religion's first period of development there is a certain freedom for personal experience and interpretation. But gradually, as

the organization in dogma and cult advances, ever narrower limits are set to the free spiritual life of individuals. Just as the Church reserves to itself the decision what is a miracle, so it arrogates to itself the decision what is religious experience, and how it is to be interpreted. That is why the mystics of the Middle Ages would revise, in calmer moments, what had been set down after their visions in the moments of rapt ecstasy, so that nothing should stand in it that “ran counter to the utterances of the holy Fathers.” Yet the handed-down and sanctioned representations had already, unbidden, woven themselves into the visions themselves. Where authority and tradition thus hold sway in the religious domain, consciously and unconsciously, it is settled once and for all what spiritual nourishment a man needs—what he needs in order to believe and to hope, to lead a noble life and to bear up under life’s struggle. No heed is paid to the great differences among men themselves, which make it impossible for them to have quite the same models or quite the same support. And no heed is paid to the fact that a personality is finished at no stage and in no form: new experiences keep coming, in which the conviction won is to prove itself, new situations, in which the yield of life so far gathered is to show its worth. Personality can grow only along with its greater aims, and only when it does not, untried, shut itself up in fixed views. Here is a point at which the history of science holds a lesson for personal life as a whole, since it shows the necessity of rising above the familiar and the near-at-hand, and of taking up new points of view in order to understand the new. Science can work with its highest thoughts without letting them harden into fixed forms for all eternity. And it holds of all our working thoughts together that they exist not for their own sake but for the sake of life. This must hold quite especially of the religious representations. Just as the causal principle itself is an anticipation, the utterance of an intellectual hope for which the work of thought seeks confirmation, so too religious propositions will be able to keep their significance—and perhaps first truly gain it—when they are understood essentially as expressions of the great hope for the preservation of the values of the spiritual life, even though those values are to take on new shapes under new conditions: a hope that is, in truth, the conscious or unconscious presupposition of all serious striving.

There is nothing restless or Tantalean in this way of viewing things. It is once and for all so, that neither in the inner nor in the outer world is there absolute rest. At the summits of our striving, wonder at the life within us and around us will naturally break forth and find expression in the greatest images our thought and imagination command. But if it is not to become fruitless raving, it must prove itself active in continued work, however hidden that work may be. There is a natural rhythm between

the great enthusiasm and the quiet labour, a rhythm that holds in equal measure for the life of faith and for the life of thought.

4. As we have seen, ever new tasks present themselves to science, and existence stands inexhaustible before it, for all its constant advance beyond its beginnings. There is an irrational relation between thought and existence. But a corresponding relation holds between the personal life of man and the forms in which he expresses his faith and his hope. Since personality embraces other elements than the intellectual, it will hardly ever be able to find in science the full expression of what stirs within it. There will therefore appear, at every standpoint, a difference between knowledge and faith—a psychological claim that closer inquiry will constantly find borne out in the particular cases. Every single personality is a centre of experiences that could be gathered nowhere else in the world. The deeper the experience of life goes, the more individual it is, and the harder to translate into general laws and points of view; indeed, the mere putting of it into words is already a difficulty. Only of late have the psychologists become seriously alive to the significance of individual differences. Human life is like a meadow. Most people see only the even green; one must part the blades to become aware of the manifold life stirring beneath them. Every man who is more than an echo of his surroundings builds his conscience and his faith, without knowing it, upon the experiences he has himself made. What gives life value—and so determines our greatest hope—everyone must learn for himself; and all teaching can aim only at helping the individual to make his experiences of life in his own way, as the peculiar centre of life that he is.

This point has long been emphasized by Danish thinkers. A. S. Ørsted declared, with Treschow, that the peculiar and the individual cannot be exhausted in concepts; and he draws from this, for ethics, the consequence that no general moral commandments can exhaust what is required in the particular case, and, above all, that such general rules cannot let the individual's own peculiarity come into its own. Everyone must therefore, in a certain sense, have his own ethics. Sibbern laid great weight on the fact that in every domain development begins from scattered points, so that connection and community come at the end, not at the beginning. Thus spiritual development too begins in the several personalities, in which life stirs in different ways; and only through their interaction can it then appear whether a community can come about. All that is later understood as objective doctrine had its first origin in the inmost recesses of single souls. In the religious domain especially, unity has value only when it comes as the natural consequence of the same knowledge being won by all. To dogmatize is to tear the truth loose from its living root, to make a mummy of it and let it be handed down in that

shape from generation to generation. Poul Møller pressed the notion of personal truth, as against the affectation that lets a man believe and behave as though he had other experiences and other strivings than he really has. He was convinced that a thought which truly answers to a self-won conviction cannot be wholly wrong; it will always have its significance from some point of view, however limited. Søren Kierkegaard developed, in the sharpest possible form, the doctrine that, in the great truths of life, everything turns not on what is said but on how it is said. It turns on personal inwardness, on the passionate striving and seeking; and even the most correct and truest content of faith becomes personal untruth where this most essential condition is wanting. This is what he utters in his paradoxical proposition: Subjectivity is the truth². It is by no means a sign of doubt or weariness when such stress is laid on personal truth, as against an objective doctrine about the worth and meaning of life. It springs, rather, from a conviction living among our older Danish thinkers that personality is the soil—or rather the seed—from which alone real wisdom of life can grow. What for science belongs among the last objects, to whose fathoming all general laws are to minister—personality as a peculiar little world—is, for the view of life and for faith, the decisive starting-point.

Every psychological discussion of the religious problem must take account of individual differences. Accordingly, in my “Philosophy of Religion,” I sought to survey both the most important oppositions among original dispositions and the differences between the religious types answering to those dispositions. In the first respect I find, as regards knowledge, an opposition between natures in whom reflection and after-thought play the leading part, and natures who hold as long as they can to intuition and who, where observation does not suffice, would rather form images than give themselves up to the movement of thought. Within the movement of thought there is again a difference between natures that prefer to go into the particular, to resolve their observations into the simplest elements—analytic natures—and natures that strive of themselves to bind all observations and all thoughts into coherent wholes—synthetic natures. As regards the life of feeling and will, I find first and foremost an opposition between natures in whom various mutually contending moods and drives are astir—disharmonious natures—and natures in whom the whole life of mood and drive reaches out beyond the individual’s own bounds to find an outlet and an expression for its energy—expansive natures. There is, further, a significant opposition between passive and active natures—between those whose inner life moves by fits and starts and those in whom it unfolds continuously—and between those most taken up with what stirs within themselves and those in whom an

²In *Udvalgte Stykker af dansk filosofisk Literatur* (1910) one will find the most characteristic utterances of the Danish thinkers mentioned.

immediate urge to self-surrender prevails. Where these differences hold—and surely still others as typical—and where they can combine in various ways with one another, it is plain that both experiences and interpretations must come out differently. And so, when we study the chief psychological forms of religious faith, we find very different types even among those who hold to one and the same confession. I have tried to describe seven such types. Faith can be a rest from inner and outer strife, or a free and harmonious unfolding of the spiritual life. It can bear the character of contemplation, or of trustful venture, or of resignation. It can be the convulsive holding-fast of an isolated individual, and it can be the childlike trust in tradition of “the charcoal-burner’s faith.” The most important of all these oppositions is surely that between the disharmonious and the expansive natures—between those in whose mind contending forces stir, and whose urge is essentially toward finding rest, and those in whom a great force and fullness presses forward, and whose urge is therefore toward finding outlet and form. The life of the first will show sharp crises and oscillations; that of the second will run rather like a steadily advancing stream. — This opposition too has been strongly emphasized by other psychologists of religion, and possibly all the rest can be traced back to it. —

As a rule, in the development of the religious consciousness, the passage from experience to interpretation takes place very quickly. This is bound up, as already noted, with the fact that the individual finds, in the handed-down religious representations, an interpretation lying ready in advance. Tradition—the confession prevailing in society—does not first speak when it is a matter of finding form and expression; its content weaves itself unbidden into the seemingly immediate experiences, into visions and representations supposed to arise wholly at first hand, from purely inner sources. The prevailing confession does its work later, then, when a conscious and thoroughgoing interpretation and account of what has been lived through is to be given. It has great power, being definitely formed and elaborated; it impresses by its age, and works perhaps even compellingly through its social organization. Religious experience therefore consists for the most part in this: that individuals seek to rediscover and confirm the handed-down representations in their own personal life; and often they have then forced out supposed experiences, states that in reality had no root in their nature. It became, in Poul Møller’s phrase, affectation, not personal truth. Hence the convulsive form religious life has often taken, of which the religiosity of Pascal and of Kierkegaard are such typical examples. All his genius, all his rich life of mood, and his whole energy of will Kierkegaard put into the service of the task “to read the primal writ of the individual, human conditions of existence — the Old, the Familiar, and what is handed down from

the Fathers — through yet once more.” Experience of life thus becomes no independent and original source of faith; the possibility and the legitimacy of new interpretations are cut off in advance. The church historian Gotfried Arnold wrote in his day (1715) a book he called *Theologia experimentalis*, which is interesting for more than its title. In it he maintains very definitely that in ecclesiastical theology experience must hold a different place from the one it holds in science. In science experience is an independent source and comes before faith; but in religion (confessional religion) it must come after faith, being a schooling in what the Bible teaches, and must always “be judged according to God’s Word.” Here Arnold sees far more clearly than many a modern theologian who, without more ado, sets the place of experience in the ecclesiastical and in the scientific world on a par. There is, after all, a great deal in ecclesiastical theology that no single person can have experienced and that is yet to be believed. It is then accepted essentially on trust in the tradition of the congregation—a kind of charcoal-burner’s faith (*fides implicita*). The Catholic Church, moreover, is so liberal as to require of the laity only a faith of this kind, a childlike trust that the Church has the truth, even where that truth passes beyond what the individual can experience or understand. It was inconsistent of Luther to condemn a faith of this kind, just as it was inconsistent of Kierkegaard to lay such weight on “the Old, the Familiar, and what is handed down from the Fathers,” while at the same time proclaiming that Subjectivity is the truth. The free experience of life has been hampered by the preponderant part that tradition has played in religious life. The eye has been shut to many sides of life—of the inner life of the spirit as well as of the outer life in its manifoldness and extent. It is through this that the whole labour spent on a scientific understanding of existence has come, in advance, to be regarded as hostile, or at any rate indifferent, to the personal view of life. And men have been inclined to fix a single personal type as the normal one, a universal model. There lies here a contradiction in all religion that rests essentially on tradition: it cannot explain its own beginning. A new religion is founded, to be sure, never on bare ground; there is always a traditional foundation. But the tradition that makes up the founder’s spiritual atmosphere must nonetheless undergo an essential change under the influence of his personality and his experience of life. Here something new is inserted—a “mutation” takes place, to borrow a biological term—which may hold great riddles for historical research and psychology, but which must be acknowledged if the very rise of the later prevailing tradition is to be understood. The difficulties in this are often hidden by the fact that men take the founder ready-made, whereas his figure first shaped itself through the successive development of the tradition itself.

Experience must, in the domain of the view of life as in that of science, be acknowledged as an independent source of faith, if personal truth is to come into its own. But here a new difficulty arises. Science has recognized that an assumption is not fully proved merely because the facts can be understood by starting from it. It must also be possible to show, conversely, that from the facts one cannot arrive at any other assumption—that they admit of this one interpretation only, and that no other assumption whatever is possible. This is why—as already touched on—many investigators hold that the fundamental principles on which natural science has hitherto worked, and from which it has managed to explain so many phenomena so exactly, are not themselves fully proved, since one cannot show that it is impossible to reach the same results from other fundamental principles. Leibniz had already declared that a hypothesis's success is no proof of its truth; one must also be able to show that it is the only possible mode of explanation. For one and the same conclusion may, after all, be reached from widely different premises. If we now apply this to the personal view of life, it is clear that it will be impossible to show that a man's experience must lead him to some wholly definite kind of faith—whether that faith coincides with the faith of the society in which he grew up or is formed anew and independently. And here, from the nature of the case, no counter-test can be made. Art is long, but life is short—and this holds too of that art of living which finds expression in a man's faith. But it is not time alone that forbids a counter-test. In a faith, or a view of life, that is really the personality's own possession, comparison with other views is ruled out. It is here as with a grave decision: the will has so concentrated itself that all other possibilities pale; the time for comparison is past. Once the whole inwardness of the mind and the whole personal experience of life has been laid down in our conviction, we can no longer seriously debate the question whether we might not, given our inner and outer conditions, have come to another result. Kierkegaard somewhere in his diaries touches on this point, imagining the objection raised against his faith: "Yes, but it was, after all, also possible that you might have been saved in another way." He rightly says that to this the believer can make no answer; if he answers the objection, it is a sign that he is in reality no believer. This is psychologically true; so are we all placed, whatever our faith may be. But from it there follows, of necessity, a limit to all dogmatic wisdom. At no point in life is experience exhausted—and even were it exhausted, a conclusion drawn from it would not be absolutely compelling. It must counsel caution. And when science itself here sees a bound to the incontestable validity of its own assumptions and results, faith must make the same admission on its side. Every faith is a venture, an anticipation, and it must not so settle into repose—in the individual's mind, or in

structures of doctrine and social order—that it forgets this.

Experience and life are the broad, deep foundation on which both the scientific and the religious concepts are built up. All our concepts are owing to reflection upon what is immediately and involuntarily experienced and lived through. It is this foundation (the subject) that is gradually interpreted and determined through the assertions (predicates) we put forward in thoughts and words. All our concepts are, to begin with, predicates. In our simplest judgments only a single word is uttered, a single concept formed—namely the predicate. So it is in the pure exclamatory judgments, for example “Beautiful!” “Glorious! Great!” The predicate is the one thing a judgment cannot do without; all the rest can be understood tacitly. Often we can only point to what the predicate holds of, without being able to name it—and this will be so above all in exclamatory judgments. Now if all wisdom, the scientific as well as the religious, begins with wonder, then exclamatory judgments will naturally be among the first. Only later can our concepts undergo such a fixing and determining that they can figure as subjects. But it is of great importance to hold fast that the nearer we come to our original, most unspoiled experiences, the more our concepts are mere predicate-concepts. This is their first stage, to which every thorough discussion must return. And the religious concepts in particular are constantly in need of revision in this direction. The very concept God is thus a predicate-concept; it arose as a thought-expression for experiences and things lived through. This becomes clear as soon as one asks what makes God God, or wherein God’s divinity consists. It then appears that in the concept God there are gathered, at every period and for every kind of religion, the most precious properties that men found revealed in existence and in the march of destiny, as they knew and understood it. It is the common trait beneath the infinite variety in the representations of God. And it is to this that religious discussion will always in the end come back, however hard it may be to discover a concept’s true hour of birth. The question for the individual will be whether, according to his own experience, he can repeat the process by which the handed-down religious representations first came to be. Perhaps those representations must be considerably altered if his experience is to endorse them. Perhaps he will come to form quite other representations, if he is to be true to his real experience. It may be impossible for him to form any wholly definite representations at all, or he may come to see that here only images and parables can help him.

Here we stand at a chief vantage-point for the religious problem of our day. On many points the strife will, as before, be waged from the side of natural science, of historical criticism, and of critical philosophy. But science and philosophy cannot bring

forth faith, and are not enough for a personal view of life. Faith and the view of life grow of themselves out of life, and thinking plays its part more as a limiting and testing power than as the positively producing cause. Science can only require that, just as little as it claims to be able to fathom existence, just so little must religion imagine that it could ever furnish universally necessary and exhaustive expressions and forms for the experiences of personal life. A distinction must constantly be drawn between experience and interpretation. It is this distinction that Danish thinkers have sought to impress with their demand for personal truth, and whose importance the newest psychological research drives home. It is no longer merely a matter of interpreting old books or confessions, but of interpreting life itself—the life that is richer and deeper than any tradition can express. If new wine is gathered along this path, it will appear whether it can be held in the old wineskins.

The recognition of religious freedom has been a step forward toward opening the possibility of a free personal life. Religious freedom rests on the assumption that outside the closed ecclesiastical communities too a worthy and noble human life can be led. At first it was wrung from the holders of ecclesiastical power; but it is becoming a positive principle, an expression of trust in the independent significance of human experience and human development. The more the Church gives up working through outward power and as a state institution—that is, in the course of its progressive separation from the State—the more room, and the more need, there is for independent experience of life. The Church itself will come to work for its ideals under other conditions than before; for the first time since its heroic age it now steps down into the arena, and is set on an equal footing with the other human endeavours after what can make life great and beautiful. And it will then be obliged to reflect more than before, and notably with greater clarity, on the foundation of experience upon which it can build. As long as it was the Church's own traditions that, in more or less pronounced form, set the whole spiritual atmosphere in which every individual grew up, its work was not so hard. For the most part it consisted in bringing forgotten childhood melodies and homely memories to life again. Now it will be obliged to build its edifice up from the ground. And as for the Church's opponents, the changed conditions will gradually bring this good, that criticism of what has been handed down will no longer take up so much of the time and force of those who strive independently. In all too many, under the overlordship of the religious traditions, a fear of and a reluctance toward every positive view of life were awakened and nourished; and men had grown so used to a critical attitude that they forgot how merely preparatory and provisional all criticism is. Now indifference or a

want of trust in the positive unfolding of life in new forms, now sheer blaséness, was the result. It will perhaps be long before the unhappy consequences of dogmatism are overcome. But it is, after all, an old saying that he who believes is in no hurry.

Perhaps the strife will prove eternal between those whose thoughts about life can be cast in a confession they share with others on the ground of tradition, and those whose inner life—be it an advantage or a defect—cannot be set to rights in this way. A spirited Danish clergyman once said: “A seeking congregation is an absurdity.” It is true that a religious community must unite about a definite conception of life, and that the constant seeking must remain the individual’s own affair. There are, too, many historians of religion who so stress that religion is a social phenomenon that they take no interest in the more individually marked forms of faith—which are nonetheless both the starting-points and the high-points in the history of religion. But from the point of view with which we are here concerned, the question becomes whether life always stirs more strongly in those who have every dogmatic rubric filled in than in those who, for all their serious seeking, come to rest in no concluding confession. If the inmost, the most personal, the most precious thing that can be lived and experienced could be expressed in no dogma—as little as in any scientific proposition—was it, then, an absurdity to be a seeker, and to go on being one?

This is the most important question that can be raised in our day. Its answer forms the decisive dividing-line. Its significance lies in impressing upon us that in life, as in science, it is in the end a matter of building on experiences one has made oneself, whose interpretation one does not take at another’s hand. The individual develops, in life and in science alike, under the influence of the traditions of the race, the venerable and the questionable together. They are for him now a help, now a hindrance. But whether, in the particular case, they are worthy of honour or not, and whether they are help or hindrance—that, in the end, only his own personal experience can decide.

The strife in the world of the spirit will be waged under better conditions than before, if this way of viewing things wins more and more its way. And only if that comes to pass can one who cares both for the freedom of thought and for the richness and inwardness of personal life look to the future with confidence.

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